

was celebrated abroad as one of the world's greatest living musicians. In the early 1890s, he was still full of ideas and plans, and busied himself writing the opera *Iolanta*, the ballet *The Nutcracker*, and the *Symphony No. 6 ("Pathétique")*, a work he dedicated to his nephew, Vladimir ("Bob") Davydov. The young man, who was 30 years Tchaikovsky's junior, was the subject of the composer's obsessive but ultimately destructive love.

Within days of the symphony's premiere in 1893, Tchaikovsky contracted cholera during an evening at his favorite restaurant in St. Petersburg. The illness proved fatal. There is speculation that he may have drunk unboiled water on purpose in order to commit suicide. No definitive conclusion has been reached.

“ To regret the past, to hope in the future, and never to be satisfied with the present: that is what I spend my life doing. ”

PYOTR ILYICH TCHAIKOVSKY, IN A LETTER TO HIS BROTHER ANATOLY, 1878